

Project 1A: Annotated Bibliography

Riley Schillinger

Research Question

“How do online developer communities perceive free labor?”

- **Source 1:** Deng, Xinyu. “The Free Labor of ‘Local Guides’: How Google Translates the ‘Hacker Ethic’ into a Data-Accumulation Culture.” *Big Data & Society*, vol. 13, no. 1, SAGE Publications, Feb. 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1177/20539517261421477>.

In “The Free Labor of ‘Local Guides’: How Google Translates the ‘Hacker Ethic’ into a Data-Accumulation Culture”, the topic of community-contributed content to Google Maps is related to the company Google turning free labor of “hackers” online into their own unpaid content farm. The article uses lots of quotes and statistics from other articles and sources and analyzes them together to look at this strategy employed by Google (Alphabet).

The source is both relevant to my research question and quite persuasive. It covers free labor within online communities, the relationship between Google and the users doing this unpaid labor for them, and other information about community contributions and open-source software.

The source provides proof that a big company like Google has community programs like this, and it provides an alternative perspective by being able to look at how free labor in online communities looks at a large scale in a corporate context. It also provides information about open-source projects that will be useful to build on, as OSS, or maybe better known as FOSS, is a big topic when talking about free labor in online developer communities.

My reason for choosing this source was because of the points I made in the previous paragraph, it will allow me to show the readers free labor in online communities in the context of a large-scale corporate operation, and possibly one of the “worst-case” scenarios within the topic. It is very strongly connected to my research question, so it would have been a poor decision to leave it out. It also pulls lots of information and statistics from many sources.

- **Source 2:** P. Vallas, Steven, and Anne Kovalainen, editors. *Work and Labor in the Digital Age*. Emerald Publishing Limited, 2019.

In “Work and Labor in the Digital Age”, the topic of freelance work is analyzed in respect to its new form in the digital age, with the article looking at the “gig economy”, the platforms that came about because of it, and how companies have changed regarding the shift to the digital age and all of these new freelance opportunities. The author supports this by presenting lots of sociological and political economy studies throughout the work. There are plenty of case studies also brought up to support an important point about how many people who distribute their creative works online are freelance creators for the platform of distribution, citing “Flappy Bird” and “Gangnam Style” to name some of the viral hits the authors mentioned.

The source is relevant to my research question because it discusses freelance work in the digital age. Not only that, it discusses free labor in several places throughout the work. It creates a reference point to speak on royalties and publishers in this digital space that could be considered free labor, so it becomes something interesting to jump off.

This source will help due to this, since it brings up both freelance work in the digital age, free labor, and new perspectives and topics relevant to the research question that will be very helpful to build on.

Royalties and publishers aren't often considered in the conversation of free labor, but it is a very important point that should be discussed, because it is an interesting relationship between creator and publisher, and the creator could be considered both doing free labor for the publisher and not.

I picked this source specifically for this reason; not only because I thought that it would relate to my research question splendidly, but also because it brings interesting topics to the conversation that can appropriately flesh out the answer to the research question.

- **Source 3:** Vercellone, Carlo, and Antonio Di Stasio. "Free Digital Labor as a New Form of Exploitation: A Critical Analysis." *Science & Society* (New York. 1936) [Los Angeles, CA], vol. 87, no. 3, July 2023, pp. 334–58, <https://doi.org/10.1521/asis.2023.87.3.334>.

In "Free Digital Labor as a New Form of Exploitation: A Critical Analysis", the main topic is how user-generated content like videos, images, comments, and other things of the like create value and "network effects", or simply, how this free labor is exploited by the platforms that invite it for their own benefit.

This is heavily relevant to my research question, because it again brings up explicitly the concept of free digital labor. It can also relate to online communities because of the direct link between UGC (user-generated content) and free created value for the platforms hosting the online communities. Even platforms like Reddit that are the main sources of community information are guilty of this!

This source will help me expand on the first source by providing information on how both big and small platforms utilize UGC to generate value for themselves for free. It provides a unique perspective from the first source, expanding the definition of free labor from dedicated efforts to even simple usage of a platform. By showing this perspective, it lets me build on the concept of free labor and gives a better platter of information to source when attempting to use online community content with academic sources.

I chose this source because of how it allows me to expand the definition of free labor in the digital space, which brings readers to a closer understanding of this topic and allows an easier time of integration with online community comments that will be researched later on.

- **Source 4:** Chiu, Jeng-Jr. *Digital Labor in Social Media Theater: A Study on Graphic Creators*. 2023. ProQuest Dissertations & Theses.

In "Digital Labor in Social Media Theater", the main topic is how digital graphic artists deal with social media and content creation to stay afloat within the aforementioned "gig economy". This meaning that they must become popular and stay popular enough to be able to get work. This is supported with references, statistics, and quotes from other academic sources cited throughout the work.

This source is relevant to my research question because it covers labor in the digital space in a way that speaks both on what was discussed before in source 3 with UGC providing value to the platform that hosts it as well as providing evidence towards negatives associated with these platforms and free labor at large.

This source provides evidence of people trying to stay afloat with freelance work, showing a predatory side of these platforms by profiting off of the desperation of people trying to get work online. This alternate perspective lets the reader step into the shoes of a digital freelance worker and understand the trials and tribulations of the occupation along with how their work is exploited to create value for the platforms they try to use.

I picked this source because it could bring another unique perspective to the table. Most of the works talk about VGI or programmers and average users, but this covers freelance workers and the effects of desperation to keep an online presence to maintain financial stability.

- **Source 5:** Yang, Zhuyuan. The Prospect of Labor in Cyberspace : Labor and Remuneration of Network Users in the Relationship Between Technology and Power. 1st ed. 2024., Springer Nature Singapore, 2024, <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-97-8756-2>

In “The Prospect of Labor in Cyberspace: Labor and Remuneration of Network Users in the Relationship Between Technology and Power”, the main topic is again how users are exploited for their UGC and how it is monetized without compensation for those users. This is supported by, again, academic sources and other articles that are pulled for quotes, information, and statistics.

The article is relevant to my research question in the same way that the third source was relevant, that it talks about free labor by users of platforms to generate value for the platform itself.

This source gives me another place to find information and statistics about UGC-generated value within online spaces that can append to my previously gathered information in the third source. It also provides new perspectives, introducing the concepts of OGC and PGC, and how this is pulled off on a massive scale by large platforms.

I chose this source because of the extra information it could give me to add to what I got in the third source. More statistics, quotes, and perspectives for me to pull from when drafting my Project 2.